"In the long term, such regularisation promotes unauthorised structures over legitimate ones. Why should anyone seek permission to develop a colony if there are no costs involved in not going by the rulebook?" the official asks.

By existing rules, in colonies where more than 70 per cent of the plots have a size of less than 1,000 sq. ft, 80 per cent of the development cost has to be borne by the municipal body and the rest by the plot owner. In colonies with bigger plot sizes, the cost has to be shared equally. But exactly how the government plans to develop such colonies remains unclear. Singh says that except granting authorisation, not much can be done in areas where a colony has not left open spaces for parks, roads and other basic amenities. "For all other development works, civic agencies have been asked to provide water, electricity connection and sewage lines," he said. Though, given the poor fiscal position of most municipal bodies in the state, their ability to carry out such upgradation activities is debatable.

OFTEN, CITIZENS WHO PAY HIGHER PRICES IN LEGAL COLONIES END UP FEELING CHEATED BY SUCH REGULARISATION

Politics aside, what is needed is a genuine and lasting solution to the spread of unauthorised colonies in MP instead of regularising them every poll season. With governments wedded to myopic policies, that has not been forthcoming. Patchy and lopsided development will be the norm as long as cities fail to provide affordable housing to all. In his May 23 speech, Chouhan made an empathetic point, "People invest their life savings to own a house, and then come to know that it's illegal. That's injustice to citizens. The stigma of being unauthorised has to be removed." While that diagnosis may be right, the remedy to that injustice lies elsewhere, not in quick-fix regularisation. ■



GUJARAT

A 'Reform' Is Rolled Back

By Jumana Shah

Just days before the new academic session was to begin in Gujarat, the state government made a surprise retreat. It scrapped the ambitious and controversial plan it had drawn up to launch special schools for meritorious students—called Gyan Setu Day Schools. In its stead, it announced a new scholarship scheme by the same name, admittedly a scaling down of ambition. The Mukhyamantri Gyan Setu Merit Scholarships, aiming to benefit 30,000 meritorious students in Classes 6-12, will cost the state exchequer Rs 500 crore annually once student beneficiaries are identified across classes over the next seven years. Students should have completed their lower primary education (Classes 1-5) from government or grant-in-aid (GIA) schools to be eligible for the scholarship. The choice of school has been left to them. That means they are free to continue in the same school or take admission in a private school—though the terms change significantly in that case.

In stark contrast, the previous policy planned to move meritorious students, after Class 5, from government and GIA schools to new bilingual-medium Gyan Setu Day Schools. They were to get free education till Class 12, with the focus on preparing them for competitive examinations. Four hundred such schools were envisioned,